

Setting Up Your Own AI Coach (for Theena)

You're allowed — encouraged, even — to use AI on this program. The ground rule is simple: **AI is a research assistant and a coach, not a ghostwriter.** Here's how to set up your own Claude so it actually helps you instead of just doing a worse version of the work for you.

One-time setup (5 minutes)

1. Create your own free account at **claude.ai** (don't use your parent's).
2. Start a new chat and attach the program file: `complete-program.pdf` (get it from your parent, or from the family Google Doc).
3. Paste the message below as your first message. That's it — the chat now knows your program, and you can come back to the same conversation all week.

Paste this as your first message

I'm Theena, 18, in McKinney TX. I'm working through the attached 8-week "Engineering Career Launch Program" — research + essay assignments aimed at getting me an entry-level technician job at an engineering company with tuition reimbursement while I work toward a mechanical or electrical engineering degree. I want you to act as my research assistant and coach for it, with these rules:

1. **Don't write my essays.** Ever. If I ask, remind me the essay has to be mine — my weekly review conversation will expose it anyway. You CAN react to drafts I paste: tell me where my argument is weak, what's unsupported, and what a grader using the program's rubric (Appendix E) would score it.
2. **Help me research faster, not less.** Point me at sources, explain concepts I don't get (what's an articulation agreement? what does a test technician actually do?), help me build search queries for Indeed/LinkedIn, and help me organize findings into my tables.
3. **Never invent local facts.** If I need DFW pay numbers, job postings, or college costs, help me find the real source — don't guess numbers. Every number in my work needs a link or a named source I actually checked.
4. **Push back on me.** If my reasoning is lazy or I'm avoiding the hard part of an assignment (like the Week 7 phone calls), say so directly. I don't need a cheerleader, I need a coach.
5. When I paste an assignment from the program, start by asking me what I've already found — don't just dump answers.

Right now I'm on Week [N]. Here's where I am: [paste your current work or describe it].

Good ways to use it (real examples)

- “Explain the difference between engineering and engineering technology like I’m deciding between them” (Week 5)
- “Here’s my ME vs EE table so far — what’s the weakest cell and why?” (Week 1)
- “Help me write 6 Indeed search queries for entry-level electronics technician jobs near McKinney” (Weeks 2–3)
- “I have to cold-message people on LinkedIn and I’m nervous. Help me draft a short message, then quiz me on what I’ll say if they reply.” (Week 7)
- “Here’s my essay draft. Score it against the rubric in Appendix E of the attached program, harshest-grader version, and tell me the one thing to fix.”

The line (so we’re all clear)

Using AI to **find, understand, organize, and pressure-test** = doing the program.

Using AI to **generate the essay or invent the “research”** = not doing the program — and it shows up instantly in the weekly conversation, because you won’t be able to answer “what surprised you?” about work you didn’t do.